of the future. From its messy outcomes could emerge a different architecture of international cooperation, one that is more sensitive to values and interests as much as to employment and culture.

It was not as if the twenty-first century began particularly well. Almost at its very start, the 9/11 attacks in New York shaped its global direction. Their consequences then consumed the world for the next two decades. Much of what unfolded could hardly have been anticipated then, including how the preoccupations of one power could help open up the pathway for another. Soon thereafter, an unnecessary conflict in Iraq led to even more unpredictable outcomes. On the economic front, a world that was recovering from an Asian financial crisis slid into a global one within a decade.

The entry of China into the World Trade Organization (WTO) in 2001 heralded a model of globalization that was to have profound political and social repercussions in many societies. Quite a few found themselves unable to compete for reasons of scale, nature of the model, or against such massive subsidies. The resulting hollowing out obviously created its own politics in due course.

As these long trends unfolded, different regions and countries grappled with their individual challenges and opportunities. Greater sensitivity to employment, protection of technologies and safeguarding of data in a digital world were notable concerns. In a more connected existence, their domestic churnings also began to be reflected more strongly on the global stage.

By the time we reached the end of the second decade, it was clear that the very fundamentals of the world order were shifting. Trend lines indicated a movement towards greater turbulence and big power contestation, challenging assumptions with which we were comfortable. What no one expected was that an already troubled world would get a ‘once in a century’ shock in the form of a pandemic. When we add the consequences of Afghanistan and Ukraine, the future looks even more open-ended. It is certainly a new world out there, quite definitely not a brave one.

SHARPENING GREAT POWER COMPETITION